social media that joining the BJP was tantamount to a "treachery of Punjab's people and of the Constitution".

For the BJP, the biggest catch was perhaps AAP national general secretary Sandeep Pathak, who was central to the party's organisational design. An academic from IIT-Delhi, he brought a methodical approach to AAP's political mobilisation, building booth-level systems, expanding volunteer networks and creating data-driven feedback loops. His role was critical in Punjab, where the party moved from 20 seats in 2017 to a sweeping mandate of 92 out of 117 assembly seats in the 2022 Punjab election. He also helped lay the groundwork for AAP's early push in Goa and Gujarat.

Of the others, on April 15, the Enforcement Directorate (ED) had raided premises linked to Mittal in Punjab as part of a FEMA investigation. Incidentally, Mittal, whose family has old RSS links, was part of the BJP-appointed delegation that went to the US to make India's case post-Operation Sindoor in 2025.



LIGHT RAYS Kejriwal, Sisodia and other AAP leaders at Rajghat, Apr. 28

THE BHAGWANT MANN-LED GOVERNMENT IN PUNJAB ENJOYS A HUGE MAJORITY, YET THE INFLUENCE OF TURNCOAT LEADERS SUCH AS CHADHA AND PATHAK ON THE LEGISLATIVE PARTY CANNOT BE UNDERESTIMATED

Maliwal was anyway persona non grata in the party after the blowout with Kejriwal in 2024.

For AAP, the coordinated exit of senior leaders will hit at the heart of its identity. The party's rise rested on cohesion and a tightly knit leadership structure. It prided itself on discipline and controlling the message it put out. That model delivered successive victories in Delhi and powered its expansion into Punjab. Now, after the loss in the 2025 Delhi election, the latest defections could create a perception of drift that has to be contained fast.

STRONG UNDERCURRENTS

The BJP also seems to have got the timing down pat. Punjab, the only state where AAP is still in power, is headed for an assembly election in February 2027. Here, the internal equations become more complex. The Bhagwant Mann-led government enjoys a massive majority in the House, yet the influence of leaders such as Chadha and Pathak on the legislative party cannot be underestimated. Both leaders were key in the ticket distribution process during the 2022 assembly election, and have maintained connections with many MLAs.

AAP leaders like Sanjay Singh and Mann have rubbished Chadha's claims that 65 MLAs from the state are in touch with him. "The party had given them respect, positions and power, but they chose to defect. They are the traitors of Punjab. They forget that the people of Punjab don't forgive traitors," said Mann, while expressing confidence that none of his MLAs would stray.

But BJP insiders echo the claim that between Chadha and Pathak, they command the loyalty of around 60 MLAs. The party leadership apparently is not keen on triggering defections that could destabilise the last year of the Mann government to avoid generating sympathy for AAP. The defection of their colleagues has already strengthened the bargaining position of the MLAs in the faction-ridden Punjab unit of AAP. In fact, the BJP is hoping that this and anti-incumbency will create enough jitters